

lost or stolen each day. More than 90 percent of the 300,000 notebooks stolen each year go unrecovered. Lost is not only the hardware and data, but also the owner's time spent obtaining and configuring a replacement. In addition, government regulations like Sarbanes-Oxley are guiding organizations towards more timely and accurate accounting for valuable assets, better asset management and control. As a result, IT administrators are making the security of mobile computers and high value IT assets a priority.

"Laptop theft poses a major risk when it comes to compromising corporate data, and it will only get worse with the increase in the use of handheld devices," said Chris Christiansen, an analyst at International Data Corporation in Framingham, MA. "People are walking around carrying corporate passwords, internal phone lists, memos and details on proprietary projects that could cause damage if such information were to fall into the wrong hands." Obviously, theft of IT assets is only one of the issues faced by IT managers. Another common theme is asset mismanagement, i.e., "Where did that thing go?" Servers and other IT equipment are regularly disconnected, moved for service or switched from one rack or IT closet to another. When the equipment needs to be returned to its original location, searching a data center to track down the missing asset can take hours or even days.

While expensive laptops used to be the target of thieves looking for quick cash, the primary aim today is the information on the device, NOT the device itself. Personal digital assistants (PDA's), servers and software systems are at high risk. A recent article by Ephraim Schwartz in InfoWorld entitled "RFID for Asset Tracking," wrote "...suppose a particular machine has customer Social Security numbers on it. You'll want to know where that box is at all times."

Location-aware applications can address the needs of the IT administrators for greater asset security, staff efficiency and